

Why AI Makes Everything Feel Easier but Less Memorable

Cognitive Effort, Memory Formation, and Cognitive Drift

Cognitive Drift Papers —Concept Note #6

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The Basic Pattern

AI reduces the effort required to solve many cognitive tasks.

Ideas appear quickly.

Summaries arrive instantly.

Writing begins with a draft instead of a blank page.

The work becomes easier.

The experience often becomes less memorable.

The core sequence is:

cognitive effort → AI assistance → reduced mental work → weaker memory formation → cognitive drift

Why We Remember Difficult Thinking

Memory is not simply the result of exposure.

It is shaped by reconstruction.

People remember ideas more reliably when they struggle to retrieve them, organize them, compare alternatives, and resolve uncertainty.

The effort itself helps build durable cognitive structure.

Solving a problem is often more memorable than reading its solution.

The work of thinking becomes part of what is remembered.

How AI Changes Memory Formation

AI frequently removes the most effortful parts of cognition.

Instead of searching for the right word, it suggests one.

Instead of organizing an argument, it proposes a structure.

Instead of recalling information, it retrieves it.

The user still evaluates the result.

But many of the intermediate cognitive steps no longer occur internally.

The task becomes easier to complete.

It may become harder to remember.

Recognition Is Not Recall

One of the most important distinctions is between recognition and recall.

Recognition is the ability to identify an idea when it is presented.

Recall is the ability to reconstruct it without external support.

AI dramatically improves recognition.

A person may immediately recognize the correct explanation once it appears.

This can create the feeling that the knowledge was already present.

But recognition requires less cognitive work than reconstruction.

A person may understand an explanation while looking at it and be unable to reproduce it later.

The Hidden Substitution

The substitution often looks like this:

reading replaces reconstruction

reviewing replaces retrieval

generating replaces remembering

recognition replaces recall

access replaces memory

None of these activities are equivalent.

They produce different kinds of learning.

AI shifts cognition toward immediate access and away from repeated reconstruction.

Why Easy Work Often Leaves a Smaller Trace

The brain tends to preserve what required meaningful cognitive investment.

An idea that demanded comparison, revision, uncertainty, and retrieval becomes woven into existing knowledge.

An idea that arrived fully organized may remain available only while the representation remains available.

The explanation feels familiar.

The structure has not been deeply encoded.

Ease can improve productivity while reducing the durability of memory.

Memory in a Distributed Cognitive System

Within **Co-Cognition**, not every idea must be stored internally.

Some knowledge can remain external.

AI makes this increasingly practical.

Instead of remembering every detail, people remember where to retrieve it, how to ask for it, and how to evaluate it.

This changes the function of memory.

Internal storage becomes less important.

Navigation becomes more important.

The cognitive system expands beyond the individual.

When Offloading Becomes Cognitive Drift

Within the **Reality Drift framework**, Cognitive Drift begins when easy access is mistaken for durable learning.

The person feels familiar with the material.

The explanation makes sense.

The concepts seem obvious.

Without the system, much of the underlying structure cannot be reconstructed.

The representation remains available.

The memory does not.

Cognitive Drift occurs when repeated access creates the feeling of learning without equivalent integration.

How to Recognize the Pattern

The pattern may be present when:

- concepts feel obvious while reading them but difficult to explain later
- AI-generated work is easier to review than to recreate
- completed tasks leave surprisingly little lasting memory
- the user remembers conclusions but not how they were reached
- information feels permanently available, reducing the motivation to encode it internally
- recalling independently feels much harder than recognizing the answer

These signs do not mean AI prevents learning.

They suggest that learning may be shifting from internal reconstruction toward external retrieval.

The Core Principle

AI makes cognition more efficient by reducing mental effort.

That efficiency is often valuable.

But memory depends on more than exposure.

It depends on the work required to build understanding.

When the work changes, memory changes with it.

AI makes everything feel easier because it removes cognitive effort. It can also make everything less memorable because that effort is part of how durable memory is formed.

The future of cognition may involve remembering less information internally and becoming more skilled at navigating an increasingly distributed cognitive system.

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